Couch Heroes
CTO Recruiting Brief and Ideal Candidate Profile

Internal use: Leadership and Recruiting

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1. Purpose

This brief is designed to help recruiters and leadership align on the CTO role for Couch Heroes, describe the ideal candidate clearly, and evaluate candidates consistently. It is not a technical requirements document. The emphasis is on the blend of product vision, strategy, financial stewardship, people leadership, and live game technology needed to build and run Couch Heroes.

2. Couch Heroes context

- Couch Heroes is an online, live game with MMO-lite scale and ongoing content delivery.
- The product includes quests, combat, and multiple gameplay modes (FPS, RPG, platforming).
- The studio is building platform services that enable cross-game asset ownership via entitlements and API integrations (asset crossover only, asynchronous sync is acceptable).
- Platform order is PC first, then mobile, then console.
- Current engineering team is early-stage: 4 backend developers and 5 client feature developers.

3. Role snapshot

Role title	Chief Technology Officer (CTO)
Role type	Strategy and execution. Hands-on when needed, especially early.
Primary mandate	Define the technical direction, choose the optimal server and services path through measurement, then ship and operate it.
Scope	Online game architecture, platform services (entitlements and integrations), live operations, security posture, engineering organisation and delivery system.
Collaboration	Partners closely with leadership on vision, roadmap tradeoffs, and cost-to-serve decisions.
Team context	Build capability in an early-stage team and

	hire the next layer of senior ownership.
Platform order	PC first, then mobile, then console.

4. Why this hire and what great looks like

Recruiter positioning: the CTO is hired to deliver three outcomes.

- Evidence-based architecture decisions: define what must be proven, run time-boxed evaluations, commit, and execute without churn.
- A live-game operating model: predictable releases, observability, incident response, player support tooling, and security at trust boundaries.
- A scalable engineering organisation: standards, ownership, hiring plan, and leadership development that turns a small team into a reliable delivery engine.

5. What the CTO owns

5.1 Vision, strategy, and technology scouting

- Set the technical vision and multi-year strategy aligned to Couch Heroes product goals and studio economics.
- Stay current on relevant technologies and vendors, applying a pragmatic build vs buy lens that considers risk, cost-to-serve, and team complexity.
- Turn ambiguity into decisions through clear options, tradeoffs, and what must be proven before committing.

5.2 Product partnership and roadmap shaping

- Partner with product and creative leadership to shape scope into achievable increments and protect iteration speed.
- Define technical gates for major initiatives (new mode, new platform, major feature) so delivery remains predictable.
- Own the technical aspects of player experience outcomes (stability, responsiveness, safety, and reliability).

5.3 Online game architecture and server direction

- Define and deliver the authoritative simulation and server approach appropriate for the target multiplayer scale, including clear trust boundaries.
- Establish practical budgets and constraints (performance, reliability, operational overhead) and ensure teams build within them.
- Ensure quests, combat, and multi-mode gameplay share core frameworks and do not fragment into separate codebases.

5.4 Platform services, entitlements, and external integrations

- Deliver a secure ownership model for cross-game assets via entitlements, including audit history, grants and revokes, safe retries, and operational tooling.
- Own the integration lifecycle for external games and partners: onboarding, versioned contracts, backward compatibility, rate limits, monitoring, and incident communications.
- Ensure internal tools exist for support workflows: inspection, dispute handling, corrective actions, and audit trails.

5.5 Live operations, quality, and security

- Establish live operations foundations: observability, release governance, staging, rollbacks, and incident response.
- Define service-level outcomes that matter to players and to the business (stability, latency, deploy safety, time-to-mitigate incidents).
- Own a security posture suitable for a live game and partner APIs: least privilege, secrets management, validation at trust boundaries, and abuse controls.

5.6 People leadership, process, and financial stewardship

- Lead, mentor, and level up the engineering organisation through standards, code review culture, and clear ownership.
- Build an engineering operating system: definition of done, planning and slicing discipline, quality gates, and predictable delivery cadence.
- Own hiring strategy and sequencing for senior technical leadership as the team grows (online simulation, platform services, operations).
- Partner with leadership on budgeting, cost-to-serve, vendor decisions, and investment tradeoffs, communicating risks and options clearly.

6. Ideal candidate archetype

Recruiter guidance: strong candidates often match one of these archetypes. Use this to widen sourcing without lowering the bar.

6.1 Archetype A: Live multiplayer CTO or VP Engineering

- Has shipped and operated online titles and owned stability and incident outcomes.
- Can set strategy and also dive into architecture and execution when needed.
- Has scaled teams and built delivery discipline for live releases.

6.2 Archetype B: Online Technical Director or Head of Online Services

- Deep expertise in real-time server direction, live ops, and trust boundaries.
- May not have held the CTO title, but has owned the hard parts end-to-end.
- Needs to demonstrate executive partnership and org leadership maturity.

6.3 Archetype C: Platform and live services leader with game shipping accountability

- Strong entitlement, account, and integration leadership with live operations maturity.
- Must still have shipped real-time multiplayer or live game features with production accountability.
- Works well when paired with strong gameplay leadership and a clear shared delivery model.

7. Recruiter screening signals

The goal is to quickly identify candidates who can own the full role, then use later interviews to validate depth with evidence.

Must-have signals

- Owned live operations for an online title: releases, incidents, and measurable stability improvements over time.
- Can describe an evidence-based architecture decision they led (what they measured, what tradeoffs they accepted, what changed after launch).
- Has built secure ownership systems (entitlements, inventory, rewards) with audit history, grant and revoke, and operational support workflows.
- Has raised engineering capability: standards that stick, mentoring, clear ownership, and a hiring plan that adds the right senior leadership at the right time.
- Can partner with leadership on strategy and finance: cost-to-serve thinking, vendor decisions, and investment tradeoffs.

Strong additions

- Experience with MMO-lite, shard or instance architectures, or comparable real-time multiplayer scale.
- Experience supporting multiple gameplay modes without codebase fragmentation through shared frameworks and explicit guardrails.
- Experience with partner integrations over time: versioned contracts, sandbox environments, monitoring, and partner support playbooks.
- Cross-platform sequencing experience (PC first, then mobile and console) with pragmatic constraints awareness.

Non-starters (screen out)

- Opinion-led scale claims without a plan for measurement, load testing, and instrumentation.
- No incident ownership or inability to explain what permanently changed after a major production failure.
- Treats entitlement and ownership as simple inventory without audit, revoke, and support tooling.

- Consistently over-architects beyond team capacity without phased de-risking and delivery gates.

8. Sourcing and outreach guidance

Use the guidance below to source broadly while maintaining the bar.

Target titles to search for

- CTO (games), VP Engineering (games), Head of Engineering (live games)
- Technical Director (Online), Director of Online Engineering, Head of Online Services
- Principal Engineer or Architect (Online or Multiplayer) with proven leadership and delivery accountability

What to look for in backgrounds

- Shipped and operated live titles with real player impact and on-call or incident accountability.
- Owned server direction or online platform services, not only client features.
- Evidence of team scaling, mentorship, and operating cadence improvements.

First-call questions (10 to 15 minutes)

- What is the biggest incident you owned, and what permanently changed after it?
- Describe a major architecture decision you led. What did you measure before committing?
- How do you prevent new modes and features from multiplying complexity and slowing delivery?
- How do you think about cost-to-serve and operational overhead when choosing technology?

9. Interview structure and scorecard (recommended)

Score 1 to 5. Require concrete examples and artefacts. Weight the first three categories highest.

Category	What to probe	Evidence prompts
Live operations ownership	Releases, incidents, stability improvement over time	Walk through your worst incident and the changes that followed.
Architecture decision making	Evidence-driven evaluations, time-boxing, tradeoffs	Describe a decision you proved by measurement under load.
Platform trust and entitlements	Ownership model, audit, revoke, partner lifecycle thinking	How do you prevent duplication and support disputes or partner mistakes?
People leadership	Standards, mentoring, hiring sequence, org design	What did you change that measurably improved quality

		and speed?
Product and finance partnership	Roadmap tradeoffs, cost-to-serve, vendor decisions	Give an example of balancing cost, risk, and player impact.
Security and abuse controls	Trust boundaries, secrets management, pragmatic risk posture	Describe a trust boundary you designed and how you reduced abuse risk.

10. What success looks like

10.1 First 30 days

- Rapid assessment of team, architecture, delivery risks, and live ops gaps, with a prioritised plan.
- Time-boxed evaluation plan for major technical decisions, including what will be proven and how.
- Minimum engineering standards and delivery cadence established and adopted.

10.2 Days 31 to 90

- Server and services approach selected with clear rationale and measured results, plus a phased delivery plan.
- A reliable online vertical slice shipped through a controlled release pipeline with observability and rollback.
- Entitlement ownership model and support workflows in place: audit, grant and revoke, safe retries, and admin tooling.
- Clear ownership across Online Simulation, Platform Services, and Operations, plus a hiring plan for the next senior layer.

10.3 First 6 to 12 months

- Stable live operation with improving reliability and deploy safety trends.
- Predictable content and feature delivery cadence without uncontrolled complexity growth.
- Architecture and processes ready to evolve from PC to mobile and console on the roadmap.

11. Technical context (minimal, for accurate screening)

- Target multiplayer scale: 70 to 100 players per shard.
- Cross-game assets: entitlement-based and asynchronous, via APIs.
- Core systems: quests, combat, and multiple gameplay modes.
- Platform order: PC first, then mobile and console.